

UPSC Intel · Daily Brief

WEDNESDAY, 16 SEPTEMBER 2026

1 must-know stories, 1 Prelims facts, 9 editorials and 2 explainers, picked from 27 stories reported. Each item links to its source; notes quote the reports.

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MUST-KNOW

High-yield stories: make notes on these. Grouped by syllabus area.

Economy

GS2 GS3

MAKE NOTES

CBIC cuts paperwork in deferred customs duty scheme to boost MSME participation and ease cash flow

The CBIC is simplifying its deferred customs duty scheme for manufacturers. Paperwork has been reduced from ten documents down to just three. Outreach programs will now handhold MSMEs to encourage scheme adoption. This initiative aims to ease cash flow and working capital for businesses. The scheme allows duty payments in monthly installments until March 2028.

Prelims: The scheme allows duty payments in monthly installments until March 2028.

Syllabus: GS2 / GS3: Economy, Governance & Policy · Prelims angle: Scheme

[Economic Times: read the source](#)

PRELIMS FACTS

Concrete developments worth a quick read: exercises, pacts, Acts, approvals, schemes, species, verdicts.

GOVERNANCE & POLICY

SCHEME

QUICK READ

CBIC to step up outreach as EMI scheme struggles to attract manufacturers

The CBIC will conduct outreach programs to encourage EMI scheme adoption. Data and documentation requirements for the scheme have been substantially reduced. These changes seek to boost domestic manufacturing and ease business operations. This aims to improve cash flow management for eligible manufacturers. The scheme offers deferred Customs duty payment for imported goods.

[Economic Times: source](#)

EDITORIAL WATCH

What the opinion pages argued: two or three lines each.

GS2 GS3 Bridging India's skills gap: National Apprenticeship Promotion Scheme faces low corporate participation

India's National Apprenticeship Promotion Scheme faces low corporate participation. Many young graduates lack practical work experience, creating a significant skills gap. Improving NAPS accessibility and support can unlock economic potential for the nation. Companies must view apprentices as long-term talent investments, not just costs. Low engagement from MSMEs and startups hinders the program's overall effectiveness.

[Economic Times](#)

GS2 GS3 AI cooperation: On Artificial Intelligence at a crossroads

The BRICS framework is an alternative to a geopolitical view of AI development

[The Hindu](#)

GS2 GS3 SEMICON India 2026: Chip away into the whole ecosystem, policy should look beyond fab units

India's semiconductor policy must now focus on the entire ecosystem beyond fabrication units. The nation should strategically dominate select points along the global chip supply chain. Incentives should secure localisation for critical materials and equipment production. Developing a skilled workforce through apprenticeships is essential for future growth. Government procurement and institutional testing capacity will support local vendors.

[Economic Times](#)

GS3 Decoding India's GDP base revision

A major driver of the revision in nominal GDP in the case of India is the improved measurement of India's unincorporated services sector

[The Hindu](#)

GS3 Best of BS Opinion: Modest charges will enable healthy growth of UPI

Today's Best of BS Opinion weighs UPI's funding model, freight corridor gains, India's AI strategy, Delhi's student housing crisis and J S Deepak's memoir...

[Business Standard](#)

GS2 GS3 China's open AI advantage may not last forever

China's open models cut India's AI costs, but create future dependencies

[The Hindu](#)

GS1 Youth discontent and the changing face of protest

Student unrest signals deeper discontent with governance, authority and democratic institutions

[The Hindu](#)

GS2 From fighting hunger to building health

India should use the BRICS stress on health not merely to share programmes but also to demonstrate how healthy living can be embedded across food systems, schools, and communities...

[The Hindu](#)

GS2 GS3 Lessons from India's smallholder farmers

India is an important voice in the Global South's rural development conversation

[The Hindu](#)

EXPLAINED

The concept behind the news, one or two lines each.

Who has to pay MDR on UPI and who stands to gain the most? What is the new UPI MDR system? How much could banks and payment platforms earn?

[The Hindu](#)

Why is there stiff opposition to the auction of Tara Coal Block in Chhattisgarh? Explained The CBA has put forth the argument that the people of Hasdeo have protected these forests for generations and are not an expendable coal reserve. They have called the auction of Tara a grave step backwards for Chhattisgarh and for India's environmental governance

[The Hindu](#)

ALSO IN THE NEWS

Reactions, previews and smaller stories: one line each.

- NITI Aayog VC defends UPI merchant fee, says businesses must be self-sustainable (Governance & Policy) [Economic Times](#)
- EPFO wage ceiling hike may cover up to 1 crore more workers: Union Minister Mansukh Mandaviya (Economy) [Economic Times](#)
- In graphs | Why private banks and foreign UPI apps stand to gain from the MDR charge (Economy) [The Hindu](#)
- FM urges industry to look beyond rate cuts to compliance and revenue; calls for robust tax policy research (Economy) [The Hindu](#)
- Finance Ministry rejects foreign influence claims over UPI MDR, says India's digital payments decisions are made independently (Economy) [Economic Times](#)
- Tonight's US Fed rate decision will cast a long shadow over India (Economy) [Economic Times](#)
- Reforms improved India's competitiveness, strengthened resilience: CII's R Mukundan (Economy) [Economic Times](#)

COVERAGE CHECK

Items — 1 must-know, 1 Prelims facts, 7 in the news, 9 editorials, 2 explainers.

Syllabus areas in the cards — Economy (1), Governance & Policy (1). **Nothing today in** — Polity & Constitution, International Relations, Social Justice & Welfare, Health, Education, Agriculture & Allied, Infrastructure & Energy, Environment & Ecology, Science & Technology, Internal Security, Defence, Disaster Management, History, Art & Culture, Geography, Society, Ethics & Integrity.

Easy-miss watch — Marine & coastal (EEZ, UNCLOS, Blue Economy, deep sea): nothing today · Digital Public Infrastructure & data governance: 5 · Political change in the neighbourhood: nothing today · Appointments to constitutional / statutory / regulatory bodies: nothing today · Defence-technology cooperation agreements: nothing today

Full text — 0 of 13 items were read in full from a free copy; the rest are summarised from the outlets' reports. Subscriber-only sites are never opened.

Sources in the cards — The Hindu 8, Economic Times 4, Business Standard 1

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